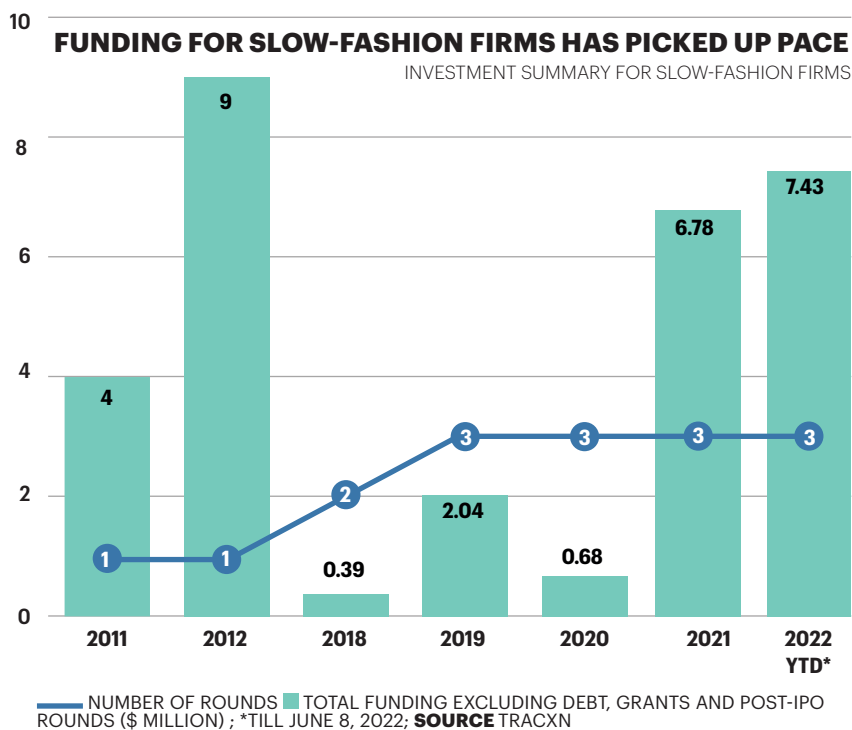




fast-fashion brands. Some initiatives are being taken that claim they're doing a lot of things, but it's one thing to say it, and another to practise it. There's a change, but it will take some time, especially because of the sheer volumes we're talking about," he adds.

Rao and many other start-up founders like him stress on the need for standardised certifications to identify and incentivise production of sustainable clothing, and they put the onus of introducing such a mechanism on the government. Currently, there are certifications such as the B Corp Certification, which certifies that a business is meeting high standards of performance, accountability and transparency on factors like employee benefits, ethical supply chain practices, and input materials used. There is also a vegan certification provided by PETA. The Aditya Birla Group, too, gives out a LIVA tag to garments made out of fabrics derived from natural cellulose fibres. These fibres are

produced using three to four times less water from wood pulp, which is sourced from trees grown in specifically designated forests.

"The main reason for the surge in sustainable fashion is the increased awareness of eco-friendly practices. Nowadays, more brands are producing sustainable clothing. From the use of plant-based textiles and bacteria-based dyes to a blockchain-based supply chain to increase transparency, we aim to stay sustainable at every step of the way," says Manmohan Singh, Head of Business Development at Birla Cellulose.

In 2019, the central government launched Project SU.RE—short for sustainability resolution—to push the textile industry towards fashion that contributes to a clean environment. Around 16 of India's top fashion retailers including Lifestyle, Shoppers Stop, Future Group, and Aditya Birla Retail pledged to source and utilise a substantial portion of their total output using sustainable raw materials and processes by 2025 under the SU.RE initiative. Industry players, meanwhile, say a more concerted effort from the government is required for ethical clothing.

Deloitte's Ramanathan cites the example of government-run Khadi and Village Industries Commission to explain how a mass-market sustainable product can be produced and marketed. "The critical driver is going to be skill-building, like the government has done through the vocational programme for khadi. It has to happen at scale," he adds.

Experts say that there are three fundamental checkpoints to call a product sustainable: one, it has to be made from raw material grown sustainably, or recycled. Second, the product's carbon footprint, right from its source to where it's sold and how it compares with the industry average, has to be lesser. And third is its post-sale utilisation and disposal at the consumer level.



"One key reason for sustainable clothing to grow in India is because it is a big hub for production of apparel and textile, and so there's a lot of learning and standards coming in from other markets"

ANAND RAMANATHAN
SENIOR PARTNER,
DELOITTE INDIA